

Deadly duo: Sharath Kamal and Sathiyar Gnanasekaran compete against Paul Drinkhall and Liam Pitchford of England during the Table Tennis Men's Doubles Gold Medal match at the Birmingham 2022 Commonwealth Games. GETTY IMAGES

here in the second round of qualification, I felt like this tournament was going to be very open for me.

How did you prepare specifically for matches against World No. 13 Darko Jorgic and World No. 22 Omar Assar in Singapore? Do you look at the rankings of your opponents when you enter a contest?

The rankings are not the final verdict when we go to play matches. In the first round of the main draw, I beat World No. 51 from Chile. I knew my game was far better than his, even though I was ranked 88th at that point. To beat World No. 51 was not difficult because I'm a much better



THE FIRST THREE WEEKS IN APRIL ARE GOING TO BE VERY HARD. I'M SPENDING ALMOST THREE HOURS IN THE GYM AND THREE ON THE TABLE



player than him.

More than the ranking, we look at the style of play, and that is why, for me, playing Darko Jorgic was a tough one because he is the opposite of me. He's covering the table a lot with his backhand. He's dominating the game with his backhand, and his passive game is very good and stable. So, even though I have the most ferocious attack, for him, it's not so difficult. He can keep making me move around the table and wait for a weaker return, and he goes for it. That is the reason why the last two



times were quite tough for me, even though the first time I played him, I had a pretty good chance. The last time, in 2022, just before the Commonwealth Games, he beat me 3-0.

This time, I told myself that what happened before couldn't pull me down. It can't weigh on my shoulder. Just because I lost to somebody

doesn't mean that I'm going to lose to that player now, and just because I won against somebody two or three times before doesn't mean that I'm going to win this time. Also, of course, if you're playing against a player you have never lost to, you are more positive, and vice versa.

As an experienced player, what I've learned is that you need to stay